Familiarity reveals uniqueness: (In)definiteness effects in Russian bare singular nouns

A long-standing question in the study of definiteness is whether languages without articles, like Russian, nonetheless encode definiteness-like distinctions in interpretation. Competing theories debate whether bare singular nouns in such languages are essentially definite and therefore presuppose uniqueness (Dayal 2004), or they are existentials without presuppositional content (Šimík & Demian 2020, Seres & Borik 2021, Seres et al. 2021). A major limitation of previous experimental work is that uniqueness and familiarity have not been independently manipulated, even though both are potential sources of definiteness. The current study separates these factors while controlling prosody. We provide the first experimental evidence that Russian speakers are sensitive to violations of uniqueness in bare singular nouns, but only when the discourse context supports a familiar referent. When the referent is non-familiar, uniqueness violations are not detected, suggesting that information structure modulates the domain against which uniqueness is evaluated.

Baseline: Word order as a cathalyst for familiarity We first tested whether preverbal vs. postverbal NP position functions as a cue to the familiarity of its referent, as widely assumed. In a forced-choice task (N=128), participants chose between preverbal (SV) vs. postverbal (VS) continuations following dialogues manipulating whether a referent was familiar or not to the Speaker. Participants strongly preferred SV continuations for familiar referents (β=–0.85, SE = 0.16, p $<$.001; see Fig. 1). This allowed us to use word order to control familiarity in subsequent experiments.

Main experiments Two parallel 2$\times$2 acceptability-judgment tasks (ExpA ad ExpB; N=60 in each) manipulated (i) Uniqueness: whether the discourse context established a unique vs. non-unique potential referent and (ii) NounType: whether the subject NP in the continuation was bare or marked by *odin* 'one'. One-marked NPs served as a comparison class that is indefinite-like as they do not presuppose uniqueness, allowing us to detect penalties specific to presupposition failure. In each trial, participants read short contexts introducing unique or non-unique referents and rated two possible continuations presented simultaneously: one with the bare singular and one with the odin-marked alternative. Continuations were presented auditorily with neutral prosody to ensure that prosodic prominence did not signal information structure; the order of presentation was counterbalanced. 32 paired contexts were constructed for each experiment (ExpA and ExpB); experimental lists were balanced so that participants viewed only one variant of each context (+Uniqueness or –Uniqueness). Familiarity was controlled in each task separately: in ExpA, all contexts introduced explicitly familiar referents and all items had preverbal subjects to reinforce familiarity; ExpB featured contexts with non-familiar referents and experimental items with postverbal bare singulars.

Results In ExpA, bare singulars showed a robust sensitivity to uniqueness and were rated substantially higher with unique referents, while one-marked NPs showed the opposite preference. We found a strong interaction effect (β = -2.31, SE = 0.07, t(870) = -31.16, p $<$ 0.001), and the crossover pattern was confirmed by both standard and robust mixed-effects models despite heavy-tailed rating distributions. In ExpB, by contrast, bare singulars were rated equally high across contexts (p = 0.24), and no interaction was observed (p = 0.5); one-marked phrases were overall rated lower and showed no systematic response to the uniqueness manipulation. See Fig. 2 for results.

Discussion Taken together, the findings show that Russian bare singulars are sensitive to uniqueness, but not always. This effect has not emerged in prior experimental work on Russian (Šimík & Demian 2020), likely because our design manipulated familiarity and provided an indefinite-like baseline. We interpret our results as follows: Russian bare singulars do presuppose uniqueness uniformly, but it is only visible in discourse configurations where the contextual domain has not been narrowed by information structure. Postverbal, non-familiar bare singulars are interpreted as focused, yielding a discourse domain narrowed to a singleton, and thus uniqueness is trivially met within the restricted domain without looking at the larger context.

ExpA (Familiar + SV), -Uniqueness	ExpB (Non-Familiar + VS), -Uniqueness
Masha and Andrey have two pet hamsters. During dinner, Masha went to the living room and saw that one hamster is gone, but the other one is still there. Andrey asks: “What happened?”	Dad is watching the news. They say that in some zoo, one of the two raccoons escaped from the cage. Mom asks: “What did they say on the news?”
ExpA (Familiar + SV), +Uniqueness	ExpB (Non-Familiar + VS), +Uniqueness
Masha and Andrey have a pet hamster. During the dinner, Masha went to the living room and saw that he was gone. Andrey asks: “What happened?:	Dad is watching the news. They say that in some zoo, the only raccoon of that zoo escaped from his cage. Mom asks: “What did they say on the news?”
a. **Xomjak** sbežal iz kletki hamster ran.away from cage b. **Odin xomjak** sbežal iz kletki one hamster ran.away from cage	a. Iz zooparka sbežal **enot** from zoo ran.away **raccoon** b. Iz zooparka sbežal **odin enot** from zoo ran.away one **one raccoon**

Table 1: Illustrative scenarios (translated and abridged) and continuations from ExpA and ExpB

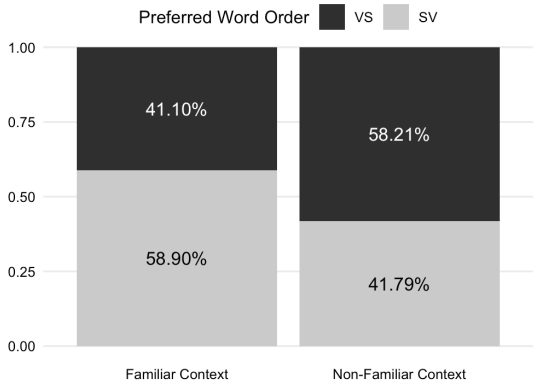

Figure 1: Baseline task

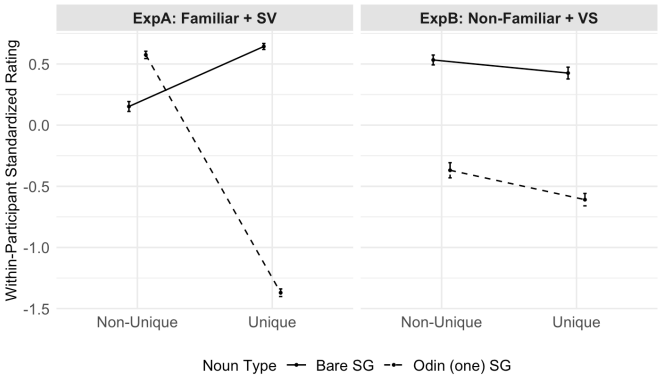

Figure 2: Main tasks

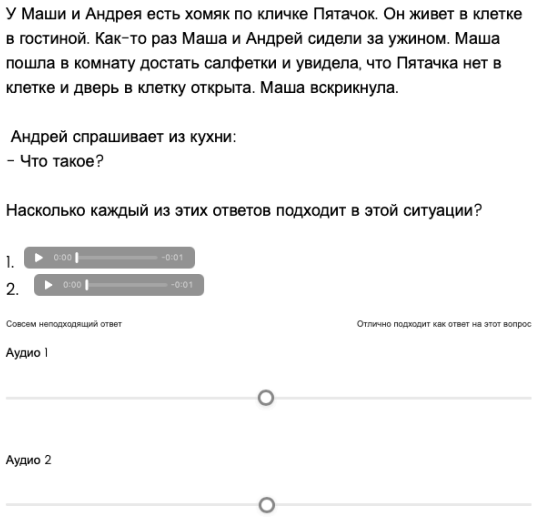

Fig. 3. Screenshot of an experimental trial, corresponding to ExpA Familiar, -Uniqueness in Table 1.

References Dayal, V. (2004). Number marking and (in)definiteness in kind terms. *Linguistics and Philosophy, 27*(4), 393–450. • Seres, D., & Borik, O. (2021). Definiteness in the absence of uniqueness: The case of Russian. In A. Blümel, J. Gajić, L. Geist, U. Junghanns, & H. Pitsch (Eds.), *Advances in Formal Slavic Linguistics 2018* (pp. 339–363). Language Science Press. • Seres, D., Borràs-Comes, J., & Espinal, M. T. (2021). Uniqueness in languages with and without articles: Catalan vs. Russian. *Beyond Philology, 18*(3), 163–195. • Šimík, R., & Demian, L. (2020). Definiteness, uniqueness, and maximality in languages with and without articles. *Journal of Semantics, 37*(3), 311–366.